takes too ‘radical’ and too ideological positions to be electorally effective. Plain-speaking by him is perceived as not theatrical enough to influence electoral success. And his repeated experiments to reform the organization from within are stymied.

Therefore, the BJY has to be seen as internally confronting this kind of fossilized understanding. Pragmatic machinations cannot be ruled out, but they alone cannot win elections. In contrast to this, in the course of my interaction with an RSS pracharak, I asked how he would respond to an electoral defeat of the BJP in 2024, and he said his work would continue as usual. Part of the strength of the BJP’s electoral success comes from it being backed by ostensibly non-electoral mobilization around the year. This creates a porous relationship between social/cultural and electoral/political work. It gives a sense of going beyond instrumental reasoning and immediacy of results. The Congress has no such ideological and social work to back its electoral mobilization.

After the electoral success in the Karnataka assembly elections, the BJY temporarily quelled such doubts. It provided a fresh relief to not only Congress party workers, but also to various sections of the society, including India’s religious minorities. In a context where the BJP partially succeeded in building a narrative of no alternatives and a ‘Congress-mukt Bharat’, the BJY demonstrated the possibility of the alternative. Under conditions of hysteria and propaganda, even Congress workers began to buy into the argument that the BJP under Modi was infallible. They bought into such an argument because they saw the process purely through an electoral lens. The fact that much of the BJP’s victory was also due to electoral engineering and not necessarily uncontested social consent was lost on many, including many Congress party workers. In such a context, the BJY demonstrated there is space for an alternative. After all, the struggle is much larger, and electoral battles are only part of that larger struggle. The BJY brought back the big picture into focus and put into proportion the success story of Prime Minister Modi and his entourage. And when the Congress again ignored mass ideological and social work (as it did before the 2023 assembly elections, relying only on the mechanics of electioneering), it lost